officer had been absent from RCSS/SSA-S operations for almost five years. Indeed, according to his own admission, he thought he had left the SSA after becoming ill and was surprised by the call up in 2010.[1] There was no indication he would directly benefit from the ceasefire agreement, yet he became a well-recognized landowner after it was signed. Therefore, there appear to be layers of beneficiaries, but their roles in the state-building project require substantiation. Second, the ad hoc vehicle police check to collect fines is an instance of Myanmar's informal economy, itself a by-product of the local political economy, which plays an important role in absorbing the deficiency in the allocation of state resources and helps maintain order at the local level. To what extent this informal economy helps sustain local order also requires clarification.

When placed together, the changing role of the lieutenant colonel, the emergence of a political economy binding warlords with the state, and a political order built on corruption and extortion are all part and parcel of a project to pacify conflict areas in Myanmar through co-optation of local armed groups. Plenty of literature discusses the political outcomes of ceasefire agreements (for example, Bray 1995; Egreteau 2012; Sakhong and Keenan 2014; Zaw Oo and Win Min 2007), political economy (for example, Brown 1999; Meehan 2011; Myanmar Peace Monitor 2013; Smith 2007; Tin Maung Maung Than 2007; Woods 2011), and state policy (for example, Kramer 2010; Kyaw Yin Hlaing 2012). Instead of repeating the arguments in existing work, this chapter adopts a different perspective, viewing the political order in the southern Shan State and the Pa-O Self-Administered Zone (SAZ) as a frontier of the state.

Benedikt Korf and Timothy Raeymaekers (2013) draw a very important distinction between a border and frontier. Although a border is often epitomized by cross-border trade, immigration (legal or otherwise), smuggling, and corruption, a borderland nonetheless is inherently central to the state because it performs the function of economic redistribution through the flows of people, capital, goods, and services. By contrast, frontiers are "not necessarily boundaries, but rather political spaces with distinct spatialities of rule and sovereign power" (Korf and Raeymaekers 2013, pp. 9–10). Frontiers are at the margins of state power (Donnan and Wilson 2001). Veena Das and Deborah Poole (2004) describe margins as the areas where the state apparatus is replaced by less organized practices that allow for the formation of a unique political economy that is different from the state. Pierre-Yves Le Muer (2006) calls it an institutional and